was my brother's father and everything. But a time came, at that plantation house, when I told him I no longer accepted this deal. He had lied to us in a way that I hadn't known adults could lie. I remember he once said all ugly people should be killed. He beat my mother from time to time, and you felt he might be capable of just about anything. I wanted him to leave, as he had promised me he would, but he denied that the conversation had ever happened.

Nomadism suits some people; it suits some people's situations. We just kept moving because that's what we did: my mother had work in a new town and we would find a house there. Simple as that. Except that the moving in these years, because of Leif, had a degree of hysteria attached, and that, in a sense, took all the simplicity away and replaced it with fear. It would take time for us to understand what the position was, and it was this: Leif Meynell was a member of an Australian cult called 'The Family'. On reflection, I can now see that his obsessional nature derived from that, as well as his egocentricity and his dark sense of control.

The Family was founded by Anne Hamilton-Byrne in the mid-1960s. It started in the mountains north of Melbourne, where they meditated, had meetings and sessions where they used LSD. The basic notion was that Anne happened to be a reincarnation of Jesus Christ, but with elements of Eastern philosophy thrown in, such that her followers beheld a karmic deity obsessed with cleansing their souls. Anne prophesied the end of the world, arguing, quite comically, though not to her, that only the people in the Dandenong Ranges of mountains east of Melbourne would survive. Anne and her husband got rich on the collections that were taken at Thursday meetings. Although the sect was never very large, they doted on her blue aura (she had a lighting system installed to keep her ever-blue), and many of them were middle-class doctors who had grown dependent. The principal power of the sect was based on a network of influence among its members. They were masonic in this way and could call on favours from high places, which explained, to us, why Leif was always able to track us down.

Leif's real surname was Hamilton. He was one of those who had been 'adopted' by The Family. Eventually, Anne Hamilton-Byrne and her husband would be convicted of falsifying adoption papers but at their height they were able to brainwash the authorities. The use of LSD meant that many of the sect members felt they had enjoyed revelations, so were happy to act as 'aunties' when it came to Hamilton-Byrne's child-acquiring mania.